



Challenging road ahead but paddlers show promise

Impressive performances at the WTT Star Contender in Goa signal a **promising shift** in Indian women's table tennis, setting the stage for upcoming challenges like World Table Tennis Team Championships.

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At the WTT Star Contender in Goa, there was a moment in Sreeja Akula's quarterfinal against Cheng I-ching when she would have felt she was a couple of points away from wresting the initiative from her Taiwanese opponent. After dropping the first game, Sreeja stormed back to claim the second at the Peddem Indoor Stadium in Mapusa. Receiving serve at 5-7 in the third, Sreeja pushed the pace in the rally, twiddling the bat in her hand and making a firm backhand

drive. It was a trick that had worked well for the 25-year-old Indian in the second game. But this time Cheng read the return well, countering with a sharp top-spinning backhand that reversed all the pressure back on Sreeja.

She defended Cheng's shot but it was only enough to set up a giant forehand that she was unable to counter. And, just like that, the